

Protecting Yourself Against Losses

It's getting more and more difficult to protect your credit cards from theft. Thieves and scam artists keep coming up with more clever ruses to obtain the information they need to use your cards fraudulently or obtain credit in your name. Even your identity can be stolen.

Keep Your Credit Cards Safe

Your best protection against credit card fraud is to know where your cards are at all times. Don't carry credit cards with you unless you know you're going to need them. Don't leave them lying around on your desk at work or in your car or anywhere else they could be accessible to others. Keep the PIN for your debit and ATM cards a secret. Don't use personal information such as address, phone number, or birth date as the basis for your PIN; those numbers are too easy for a thief to guess.

Don't disclose your credit card number over the phone unless you're dealing with a reputable company and you're the one who placed the call to them. If someone calls and tells you that you've won a prize but they need your credit card number to verify, hang up. Scammers constantly get more sophisticated. They might use "vishing" scams where a computer dialer poses as your bank and asks you to call in to discuss transactions in your account. When you get a renewal credit card or you cancel a card, cut the card up into small pieces, being sure to cut through the number. Ideally, run old cards through the shredder.

If Your Card Is Lost or Stolen

As soon as you realize your credit card, ATM card, or debit card has been lost or stolen, report the loss immediately to the bank or other issuer in order to limit your liability if the card is used fraudulently. Keep a list of your credit cards and telephone numbers in a safe place so you can access the phone number as quickly as possible.